

- Sharing poorly formatted code
- Not explaining what you've already tried
- Not giving operating system or version information
- Asking someone to write a program for you

This list of “don'ts” isn't just for decorum; these habits prevent your helpers from helping you. Your helper's first step will be to run your code and try to reproduce your problem. To do so, they'll need a lot of information about your code, computer, and intentions. It's far more common to provide too little information than too much. The next several sections explore what you can do to prevent these common mistakes. I'll assume that you're posting your question to an online forum, but these guidelines also apply to cases when you're emailing questions to a single person or mailing list.

Limit Back and Forth by Providing Your Information Upfront

If you approached someone in person, asking “Can I ask you a question?” would be a short, pleasant means to see if your helper was available. But on online forums, your helper can hold off on a reply until they have the time to do so. Because there could be hours between replies, it's best to supply all the information your helper might need in your initial post instead of asking for permission to ask your question. If they don't reply, you can copy and paste this information to a different forum.

State Your Question in the Form of an Actual Question

It's easy to assume that your helpers know what you're talking about when you explain your problem. But programming is an expansive field, and they might not have experience with the particular area in which you're having trouble. So it's important to state your question in the form of an actual question. Although sentences that begin with “I want to . . .” or “The code isn't working” can imply what your question is, be sure to include explicit questions: literally, sentences that end with a question mark. Otherwise, it's probably unclear what you're asking.